

English is a Thief

Where do English words really come from?

Global English · group presentation · 9/14

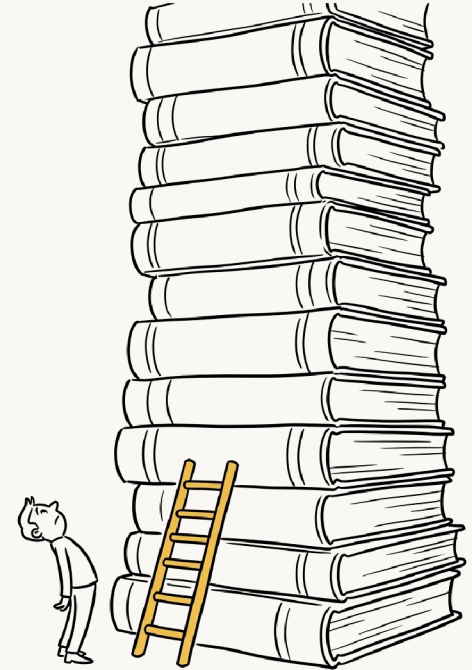
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THE QUESTION

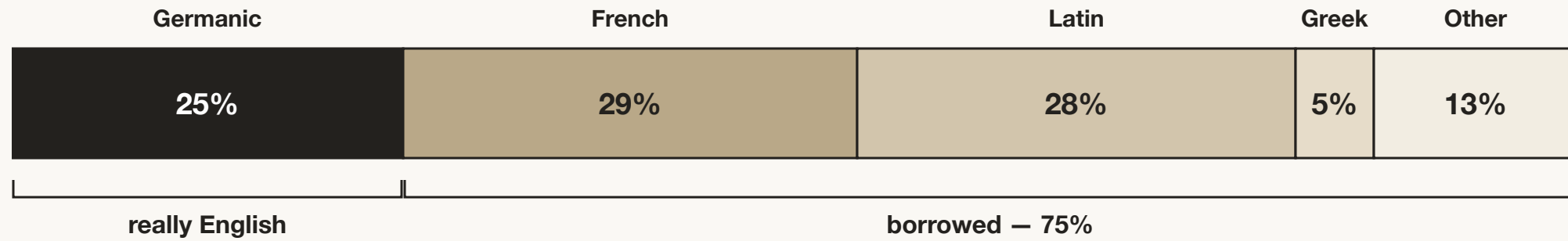
**English has about
170,000 words.**

But how many of them are *really* English?



THE ANSWER

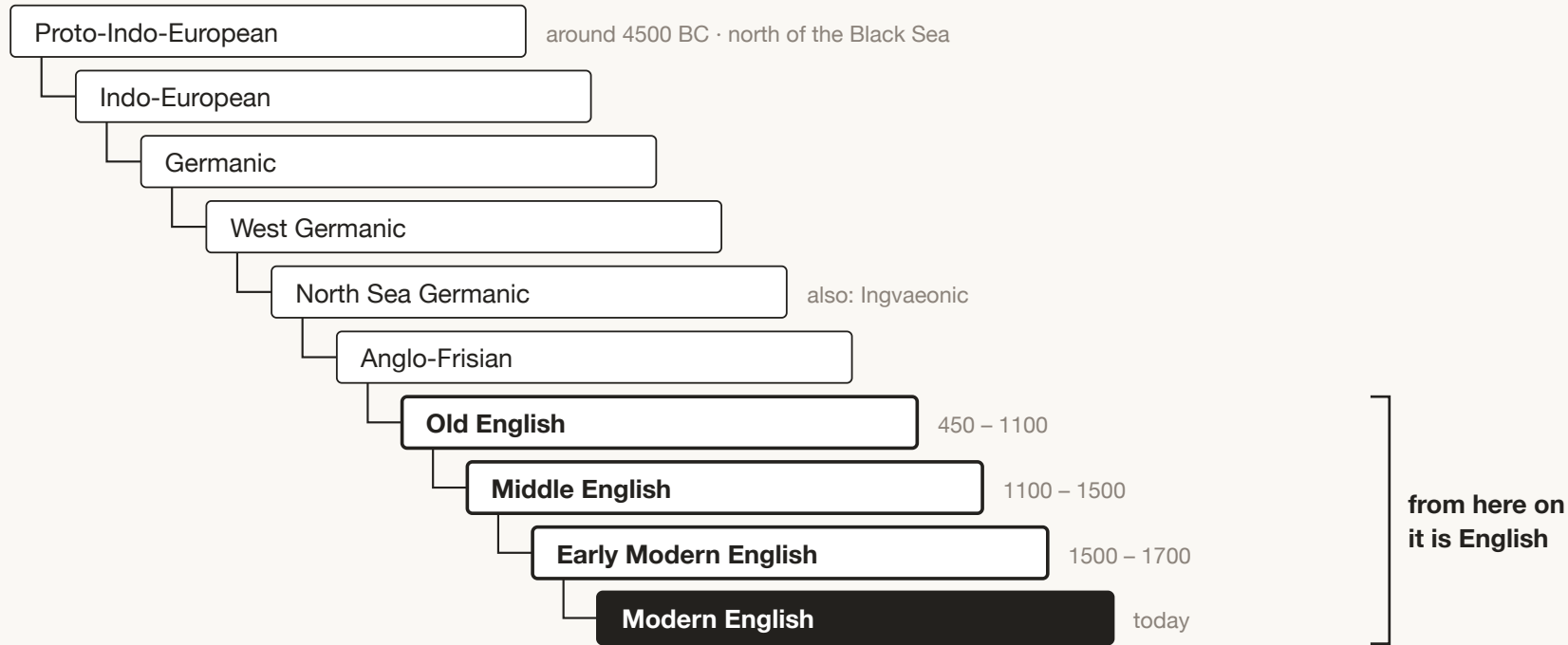
Only 1 word in 4.



Where the words in a big English dictionary come from. Numbers: Finkenstaedt & Wolff, *Ordered Profusion* (1973), about 80,000 words. But careful: the words we use *every day* — *the, is, man, water* — are still the old English ones. English borrowed the *big* vocabulary, not the basics.

So where does English come from?

It starts **north of the Black Sea**, about 6,500 years ago.



From there it spread across Europe and India — that is why English and Hindi are distant cousins. English itself was born Germanic: that line is the 25% from the slide before.

ONE SENTENCE, ONE THOUSAND
YEARS

You can watch it change.

OLD ENGLISH AROUND 1000

Fæder ūre, þū þe eart on heofonum, sī þīn nama gehālgod

MIDDLE ENGLISH AROUND 1390

Oure fadir that art in heuenes, halewid be thi name

EARLY MODERN ENGLISH 1611

Our Father which art in heauen, hallowed be thy name

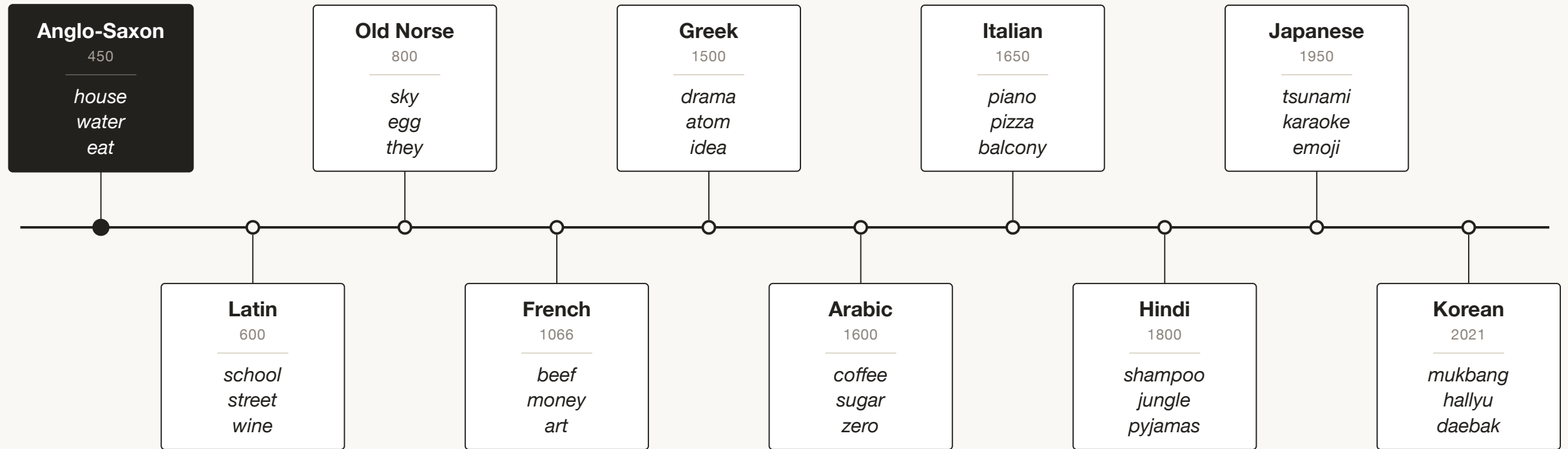
MODERN ENGLISH TODAY

Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name

Same sentence, same language.

But Old English needs a translation.

So who did English steal from?



Black box = the original English. Everything else came later. Dates are roughly when the words arrived — not to scale.

THE REASON BEHIND IT

Why did English borrow so much?

Latin	religion & education
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Old Norse	invasion & settlement
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French	conquest
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Greek	science & the Renaissance
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Others	trade
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Whenever English speakers met new people, English picked up their words.

So let's look at how that happened — starting with Latin.

THEFT NO. 1 · 600, AND AGAIN 1500

Latin came twice.

FIRST — THE MONKS, AROUND 600

Christian missionaries came to England. They taught and wrote in Latin, and the words stayed.

*school · street · wine · candle · priest · cheese ·
kitchen*

Latin is **28% of English** — almost a third of the dictionary.

We just stopped noticing.

SECOND — THE SCIENTISTS, 1500–1700

New discoveries needed new words. Nobody invented them — they took Latin again.

data · formula · species · index · focus · maximum

The Vikings came to rob. Then they stayed.

They attacked England for 200 years, and then they lived there. The two languages mixed. English kept their words:

sky

egg

knife

window

husband

law

skin

ugly

window is Old Norse *vindauga* — “wind-eye”. A hole for the wind.

And English also took these:

they

them

their

Most languages *never* borrow words like this. English did.



The French take over.

William the Conqueror wins. For the next 300 years the kings of England speak French. The farmers keep speaking English.

IN THE FIELD — ENGLISH	ON THE TABLE — FRENCH
cow	beef
pig	pork
sheep	mutton
deer	venison



The poor kept the animals. The rich ate them.

1,000 years later we still use both words.

Then English went out into the world.

British ships sailed everywhere. They came home with tea, cotton — and words.

shampoo

Hindi *chāmpo* — “to press, to massage”

jungle

Hindi *jaṅgal*

safari

Swahili — “journey”

pyjamas

Hindi / Persian — “leg clothes”

bungalow

Hindi — “a house in the Bengal style”

tea

Chinese (Min Nan) *tû*



This is how English became a world language.
Not because it is easy — because of ships and power.

QUIZ

Where is this word from?

click a word to see the answer

ketchup

chocolate

sofa

robot

tsunami

zero

AND TODAY?

English is still stealing. Right now. From us.

September 2021: the Oxford English Dictionary added **26 Korean words** at once.

hallyu

mukbang

oppa

unni

daebak

skinship

chimaek

manhwa

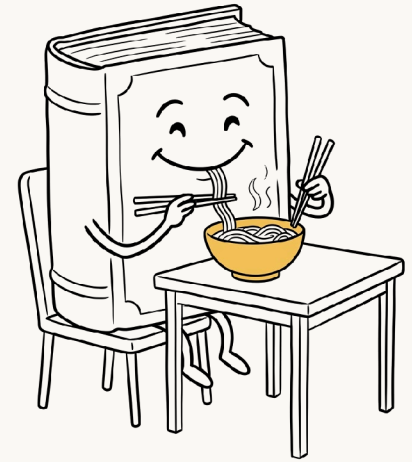
banchan

K-drama

konglish

1,000 years ago it was the Vikings.

Today it is Korea.



And Korea makes its own English.

hand phone

one-shot

eye shopping

skinship

fighting!

apart

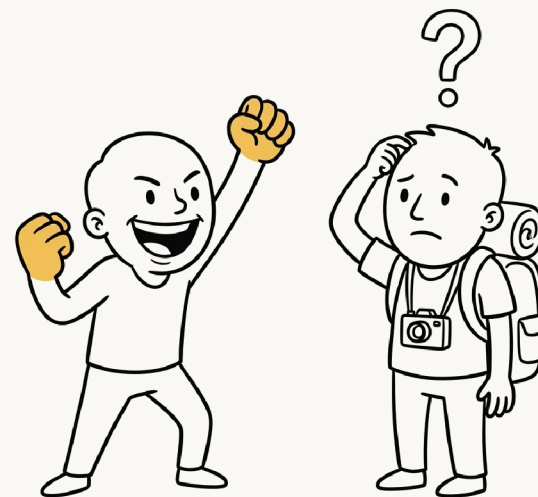
Some of these an American could guess.

fighting! — they know the word, just not what you mean by it.

skinship — most have never heard it at all.

But everyone in this room knows all six.

So — is this wrong English? Or is it just Korean English?



English is a thief.

That is exactly why it belongs to everybody.

Thank you. Any questions?



SOURCES

Where we got this from.

The vocabulary numbers — Finkenstaedt & Wolff, *Ordered Profusion* (1973), about 80,000 words of the Shorter Oxford English Dictionary

Word origins — Oxford English Dictionary and the Online Etymology Dictionary

The 26 Korean words — Oxford English Dictionary update, September 2021

The family tree — the Indo-European language family; homeland on the Pontic–Caspian steppe, north of the Black Sea

The old texts — West Saxon Gospels (c. 1000) · Wycliffe Bible (c. 1390) · King James Bible (1611)

Background — BBC / Open University, *The History of English in 10 Minutes*
